

Miners Catch Ranger In Baseball Opener

By **TIM MORRIS**

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The University of Texas at El Paso baseball team will open its 1977 season here Friday but Miner Coach Andy Cohen is not so much concerned with who will throw out the first ball as he is with who will catch it.

The Miners get things under way Friday with a 1 p.m. doubleheader against Ranger Junior College on the new diamond on the UTEP campus and Cohen is still looking for a starting catcher.

"We look to be a solid team on defense and I think our pitchers will come along all right," Cohen said. "The only position that is wide open right now is catcher. We're pretty well set everywhere else."

The Miners return an experienced infield built around senior second baseman Art Bravo. Keith Dwinell is back at first with shortstops Rusty Kennedy and Warren Cooper. Jim Bradford is also returning at third base, but may have to split time between that position and catcher, where he has been working in preseason.

"Art Bravo will be our leader in the infield," Cohen said. "He's a good defensive player and a natural leader. I think we're going to have a good, tight infield. We're not going to be real big hitters but it looks like we'll be able to play defense."

The only returning letterman for the Miners in the outfield is Bill Roberts, who will probably be joined by Sal Flores, Brad George or Jose Dominguez in the starting lineup. Flores is also being considered for the job behind the plate.

"We expect Dominguez to be a

major asset," Cohen said. "He's an outstanding player and will see plenty of action. We don't have a lot of speed or experience out there but I think they can get the job done."

The pitching ranks were hit hard by graduation last season with only two experienced hurlers coming back. David Jannush and Mike Rima, both lettermen, are expected to carry much of the load early while Miner football player Jerry Walker, transfer Bruce Daneworth and freshman Ken Miltonberger round into form.

Pitching coach Sid Cohen, Andy's brother, is also looking for help from Sam Cox, Mike Iager, Steve Hernandez and outfielder-pitcher Bobby Alsup. Of the group, Alsup is the only lefthander.

"Having only one lefthander could hurt us," Sid Cohen said. "It depends on how many left-handed hitters we face. We used to say you couldn't win without a lefthander. But then I'm left-handed so maybe I'm biased."

Cohen has been pleased with his young catchers' performances in preseason but still hasn't decided who will get most of the work at that position. Jim DiAngelo is the only returning letterman but is currently locked in a battle with Happy Anderson and Frank Juarez for starting honors. But Bradford could also see plenty of action if the Miners can find a replacement for him at third base.

UTEP will also host Ranger Saturday in another 1 p.m. doubleheader on the new field.

The Miners will play a 31-game schedule with 20 games slated for El Paso. They open Western Athletic Conference play at the University of Arizona on April 8.

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